



China e-commerce

EQUITY: INTERNET & NEW MEDIA

E-commerce sales decelerated in April Quick Note

China e-commerce sales growth decelerated to 0.2% y-y in April

The National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) on 18 May 2026 released China's retail sales data for April 2026. China's retail sales (excluding auto sales) grew 1.8% y-y to CNY3.4tn in April, during which China's e-commerce sales (excluding sales of services) rose 0.2% y-y to CNY957bn, decelerating from 2.5% y-y growth in March. E-commerce penetration in China deepened 0.1pp y-y to 29% in April.

This latest April retail sales data echoed the cautious tone we heard from the ecommerce industry in recent 1Q earnings calls about 2Q outlooks. As such, we have modeled for softening ecommerce sales growth for our covered ecommerce companies, expecting Alibaba's (BABA US, Buy) CMR to drop by 5% y-y in the coming June quarter vs 1% y-y growth in the March quarter, while JD (JD US, Buy) Retail's top line may drop by 7% y-y in 2Q26, vs 1.8% y-y growth in 1Q26.

Based on NBS data, China's online food and beverage sales rose 15.6% y-y in 4M26, decelerating from 17.2% y-y growth in 3M26. Online apparel sales recorded a 6.8% y-y increase, down from 11.6% y-y growth in 3M26. Online sales of household goods increased 2.6% y-y in 4M26, also decelerating from 3.6% y-y in 3M26.

In terms of sales for the entire retail market (including both online and offline), there was a slowdown across the board. Within staples, food sales and beverage sales rose 4.1% and 3.6% y-y, respectively, in April, decelerating from 9.5% and 8.2% y-y in March. Similarly, the daily necessity category recorded growth of 3.5% y-y, decelerating from the 4.6% y-y increase in March.

Within the discretionary categories, PC sales swung from a 15% y-y increase in March to a 6.9% y-y decline in April, and home appliance category posted a deepening y-y drop from -5% y-y in March to -15% y-y in April, mainly due to high base effects and dwindling trade-in subsidies, in our view. Smartphone sales grew 6.2% y-y in April, decelerating from 27.3% y-y growth in March, mainly due to high base effect and recent price hikes in mobile devices triggered by memory chip cost inflation. Cosmetic and apparel sales growth decelerated to 4.7% and 3.6% y-y, respectively, in April, from 8.3% and 7.0% y-y in March.

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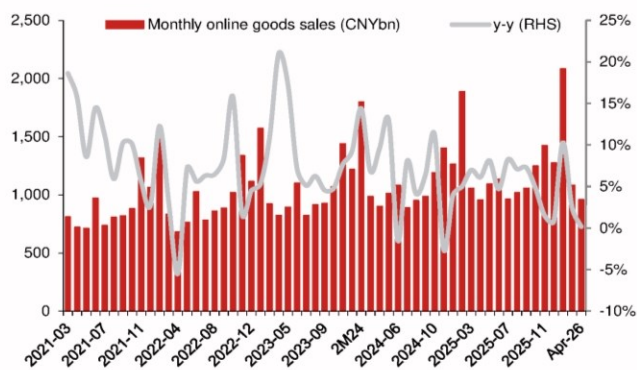
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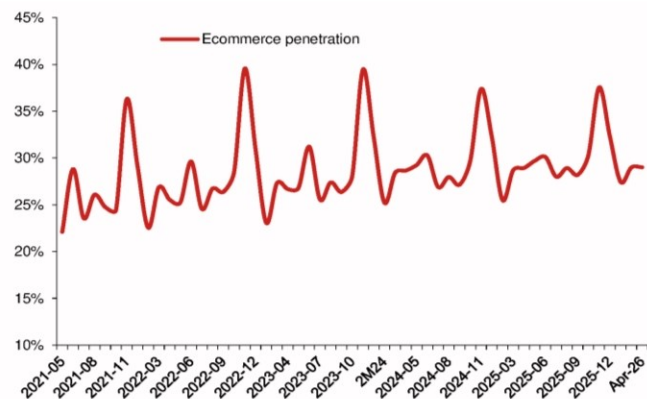
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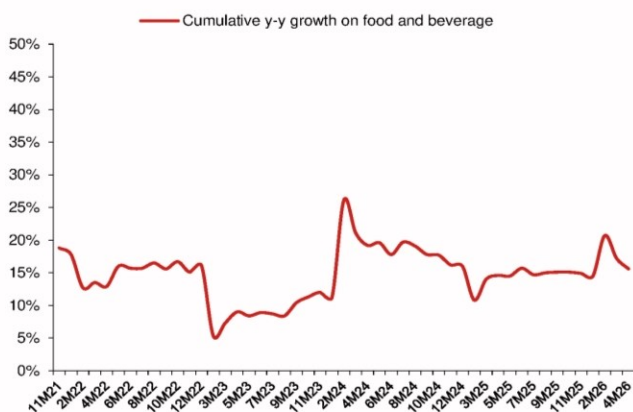
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Fig. 1: China: Monthly online goods sales and y-y growth

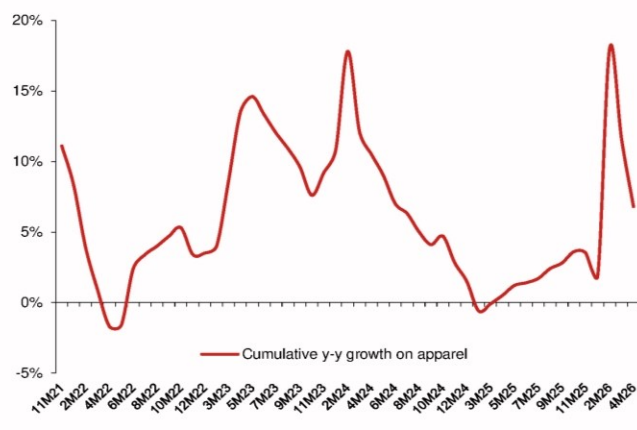
Note: Excluding sales of virtual goods.
Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 2: E-commerce as a percentage of total retail sales

Note: Excluding sales of virtual goods.
Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 3: Cumulative y-y growth of online retail sales of food and beverages

Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 4: Cumulative y-y growth of online retail sales of apparel

Source: NBS, Nomura research

Appendix A-1

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As at 31 March 2026.

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